

From the courtyards of the Alhambra in Grenada, Spain to the palace of Taman Sari in Indonesia, wherever Muslims have spread, they have constructed beautiful courtyard gardens centered around the display of water, with pools, fountains, basins and streams. The Taj is no exception, and though they will always play second fiddle to the mausoleum, the formal gardens of the Taj Mahal are a beautiful example of a Mughal water garden.

The garden's style is known as a "Charbagh," which means a garden in "fours", as the Charbagh is always divided into four equal quadrants, typically by two streams that meet (or originate) in the center. These are meant to represent the four rivers leading into heaven, because the Qur'an describes the afterlife as akin to being in a garden where there are "rivers of water unstalling" and the deceased "recline upon couches" in gardens, pastures and pavilions. The first Mughal emperor Babur took these metaphors to heart and created a garden tomb which all of his successors copied. The Taj incorporated this tradition, except that it moves the tomb out of its traditional place at the center of the garden and makes the garden a type of forecourt to the tomb itself[28].